

Chapter 131_1 - Following

After parting, longing spans but one river; returning to look back, already three lifetimes have passed¹.

As if awakening from a great dream, Ning Fuyi lay half-sprawled on the withered yellow ground, wind and sand swirling around her, the raised dust forming whirlpools in the distance, twisting like shadow demons.

She seemed to have emerged from water—trembling while soaked through, especially moist around her eyes, tears flowing like streams.

Demonic energy still overflowed. Ning Fuyi turned her head with difficulty, meeting the gaze of that person from her memories.

The same brows and features, the same white robes trailing, the only difference was the emotion in those eyes—heartache and tenderness intertwined.

"Yiyi..." she placed her palm against the barrier.

The others also stood nearby, though they didn't approach. Hua Feifei held Liu Wenzhu back while she sobbed silently. Baili Shiqi looked toward her with tears, her eyes confused, wondering what she was thinking.

Jiuying was still bound to the ground, covered in wounds. Tang Wenshu showed shock and complexity on his face. Qiuyi kept her head down without speaking. Hua Feiwu and Jiang Li hadn't awakened yet.

Ning Fuyi wanted to reach out and touch Chu Qingqiu's palm, but she quickly lowered her hand, turned around to sit cross-legged, and said softly: "Chu Qingqiu, take them and leave."

"You remember?" Chu Qingqiu saw the clue in her unusually clear eyes and hurriedly knocked on the barrier. "You remember, don't you!"

"Yes." Ning Fuyi said. She weakly let her palms hang down. "I always thought I died by your hand, always wanted to seek revenge against you. How foolish. Why didn't you tell me?"

Chu Qingqiu stiffened for a moment before speaking again: "I knew the Heavenly Dao had once again erased your memories. I thought that since you hated me, you wouldn't fall in love with me, and if you didn't love me, you wouldn't have any connection with the curse again. Perhaps that wasn't a bad thing."

Ning Fuyi nodded in agreement.

"Go away, go with them. I want to be alone for a while." Ning Fuyi said calmly. She waved her hand to shake the barrier, and Chu Qingqiu retreated repeatedly with the airflow.

"If you don't leave, do you want to watch me be devoured by demonic energy again and lose all recognition of family!" Ning Fuyi suddenly raised her voice, flicking demonic energy from her palm that cut a distant mountain peak to powder, causing the people in the distance to retreat repeatedly.

"Ning Fuyi, release me first!" Jiuying lay on the ground complaining resentfully.

Ning Fuyi released her bindings mentally. Jiuying immediately jumped up and walked quickly toward the barrier, but Ning Fuyi's demonic energy instantly erupted, the scorching black energy immediately splitting apart. Everyone hurriedly summoned their weapons to resist, but even so, some were injured.

Hua Feifei blocked everyone with a long spear, his own hand burned and skinned, blood flowing from the wound with black energy rising. He gritted his teeth: "We'd better leave this place first. She's fighting against the demonic energy. If we disturb her state of mind, it will only let the demonic energy gain the upper hand!"

"Hua Feifei speaks reasonably." Tang Wenshu covered his chest and said, then commanded: "Wenzhu, let's retreat first. Don't look anymore!"

Seeing them slowly retreating, the urgency in her heart lessened somewhat. Ning Fuyi closed her eyes: "You go too."

Chu Qingqiu trembled.

Jiuying limped to Chu Qingqiu's front, forcefully pulling her up and whispering in her ear: "Divine Venerable, just go along with her for now. With demonic energy in her body, staying here won't help. You might even be hurt by her. Better that we leave first."

Chu Qingqiu shook her head: "But..."

"We're not asking you to really leave—just don't let her see us. Wait for her to calm down, then secretly find her." Jiuying nudged Chu Qingqiu with her elbow.

Chu Qingqiu remained silent, finally compromising and slowly leaving.

Soon, under the vast sky, only Ning Fuyi remained alone. Dust rolled and spread like clouds, yellow sand occasionally galloping across the ground with whooshing sounds.

Demonic energy still tried to devour her consciousness. Ning Fuyi's vision was somewhat blurred. She picked up a stone from the ground and held it in her arms, sneering: "Ning Changfeng, look—this is all the evil I've done."

"If you hadn't insisted I live, wouldn't all these things never have happened?" She pillowed herself on the yellow sand and lay down. "As long as the demonic root isn't removed, sooner or later I'll transform into an evil ghost again."

As she spoke, she touched the Emei Thorn², playing with the sharp blade and pointing it at herself.

But just then, her palm suddenly felt warm. She looked up in confusion to see pink immortal power forming thin threads, extending across her palm and forming a glowing character.

"Love³." Ning Fuyi read silently. She was initially quite confused, then shocked to remember that this was what she had seen in the Dream Beast's⁴ illusion that day—Ning Changfeng writing in her palm.

Perhaps Ning Changfeng really had written it when she died, but she had been too grief-stricken then to remember clearly.

The pink thin threads crawled like small snakes, feeling warm. Ning Fuyi stared at them mesmerized, finally clenching her palm and putting away the Emei Thorn.

The Reincarnation Array⁵ couldn't be used again. If she died this time, she would truly disappear completely from the world. How disappointed those who loved her would be, and how happy Penglai⁶ would be.

Chu Qingqiu had used legs full of scars to retrieve her soul, and used half of the divine flower's cultivation to remove her curse. If she ended things like this, it would be too pathetic.

Thinking this, Ning Fuyi suddenly sat up, sand sliding off her back. Ignoring everything else, she summoned immortal power and crashed into her own consciousness.

On the high slope, black energy filled the air. That tree had almost been uprooted, all its fruits withered, rolling demonic energy pouring from the exposed hideous roots, making the sky appear black-yellow.

Ning Fuyi suddenly remembered that the Divine-Demon Manual⁷ not only mentioned methods to completely hide demonic roots, but also described how to seal demonic energy. So she flipped through the pages, desperately scanning those obscure ancient texts.

She read through it twice before finally seeing a string of crooked ancient characters in a corner. Immediately overjoyed, she didn't care whether the incantation was effective—she just recited it mentally, then used immortal power to trace out a complex magical formation.

Demonic energy still impacted her heart and lungs. The violent energy in her heart repeatedly reached its peak, then was forcibly suppressed. The more times this happened, the more her throat filled with sweetness.

But this was her body—she absolutely couldn't let that demonic root control her again.

Finally, the formation began to emit a soft glow. Thin silver threads rose from the formation's eye, dividing into thousands of strands that reached toward the dark demonic energy, absorbing it strand by strand into the formation.

The blackened silver threads then wriggled toward the demon tree, all flowing into its roots. The towering tree trembled and was pulled back into its growing pit.

As the demonic energy was withdrawn, Ning Fuyi broke out in cold sweat all over, her consciousness instantly returning as she collapsed to the ground.

Though the seal wasn't perfect, it had at least temporarily suppressed the demonic energy. The violence also dissipated with it, leaving only waves of gasping.

After an unknown amount of time, she finally got up and removed the barrier. Yellow sand hit her face painfully. Ning Fuyi staggered to her feet and slowly brushed the dust off her body.

She was quite disheveled now—injured inside and out, even breathing made her heart and lungs ache. She silently used immortal power to heal herself, then stepped forward, walking alone toward the other side of the rocks.

She suddenly understood Chu Qingqiu's feelings from back then. Now that demonic energy had rampaged multiple times, it would probably be difficult to seal permanently. So she could be devoured by demonic energy again at any time. If this were her previous life, it would be one thing, but now she was surrounded by people who loved her. If she lost her sanity again, one could imagine what those people would suffer.

She walked silently all the way, a figure following behind her at some unknown point—when she moved, it moved; when she stopped, it stopped, maintaining a distance.

Because her lungs were injured, using sword flight would worsen her condition, so she simply used her feet to measure the yellow sand. Fortunately, knowing the direction, she soon walked out of the Gobi and found large lakes and greenery around her.

At this time, the sky was getting dim. The lake reflected a setting sun, red and yellow and brilliant. She half-knelt by the lake, scooped up cold water and splashed it on her face. Water droplets rolled down her hair and fell onto the water surface, creating circles of ripples.

A white figure appeared on the other side of the lake, also half-squatting like her, reaching out to disturb the lake water. The evening breeze lifted her skirt like a crane standing by the water.

Ning Fuyi silently lowered her eyes, got up and continued walking, finally reaching a small city before dark.

Footnotes:

¹ **Opening verse** - A classical Chinese couplet expressing the pain of separation and the passage of time, suggesting that what seems like a short time apart feels like lifetimes

² **Emei Thorn (峨眉刺)** - Ning Fuyi's signature weapon, hairpin-like daggers associated with the Emei martial arts school

³ **Love (爱)** - The character that Ning Changfeng wrote in Ning Fuyi's palm before dying, representing her mother's final message

⁴ **Dream Beast (梦魔兽)** - A mythical creature that creates illusions and shows people their deepest fears or memories

⁵ **Reincarnation Array (轮回阵)** - The magical formation that Ning Changfeng created to bring back the dead, now exhausted

⁶ **Penglai (蓬莱)** - The celestial realm and primary antagonist of the story

⁷ **Divine-Demon Manual (神魔诀)** - An ancient text containing knowledge about gods, demons, and cultivation techniques